have matured enough to forget the past and let me get on with work; after all that was the directive U R Rao had given him. I was not totally right in that assessment, but Gowarikar himself, bitter that he was with Rao becoming the ISRO chairman, was desperate to get out of ISRO and find a secretary's job in the Union government.

I had to approach Gowarikar when our engineers who were trained in Vernon started getting back to their parent groups. Vikas was still in the workshop, and the team could not be allowed to dissipate. Here Gowarikar appeared to get a vicarious pleasure on my plight.

'You only handpicked people from different groups to go to Vernon. You did not take anyone from my group and now the others are leaving. What do I do?'

I retorted that he was very much part of the committee that selected the Vernon candidates, and he could not throw his hands up.

Gowarikar argued that he cannot hold people together to continue to work on Vikas since it was not yet a project. He, however, promised to get approval for Vikas as a project. Gowarikar did nothing, and I had to battle on.

At the PSLV planning group discussions, hundreds of configurations, sans a liquid engine, continued to be analysed. Two relatively junior scientists, Dathan and K Sivan (who went on to become the VSSC director) were in charge of simulation. Months into this exercise, still no configuration measured up. Simulations showed that some couldn't go as far as planned, some others couldn't carry as heavy a payload as we wanted. Yet others, the projections showed, would fall into a foreign country.

When I realised that my arguments in favour of using a liquid engine were being consistently and collectively stonewalled, I adopted a casual approach. During one of the water cooler moments, I told Dathan and Sivan to try out a few configurations with a liquid engine.

'But that is not approved by the group,' Dathan said.

'Hey man! I am not asking you to do anything for my house,' I would tell him. 'For curiosity sake, try it out. You don't have to make an official presentation.'